GLASSHOUSE: RAHUL'S ROUGH START PG 9

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RAJASTHAN: GEHLOT'S ACID TEST PG 10



BIG HAUL Security officials in Sukma district's Malaiguda camp with the 23 Maoists who surrendered on R-Day

MAOISTS

THE STATE OF SURRENDER

By Rahul Noronha

In the past one year, as many as seven high-value Maoists operating in Madhya Pradesh have surrendered in Maharashtra and Chhattisgarh. This includes Diwakar, a divisional commander in charge of the *vistaar* operations in the newly created Maharashtra-Madhya Pradesh-Chhattisgarh (MMC) zone of the Maoists. However, not a single Maoist has surrendered in MP since 2010. The state police say they are struggling on the information front as they have little 'access' to these key operatives.

The surrenders in other states have prompted MP to introduce a draft 'Maoist Surrender and Rehabilitation Policy', in the process underlining the inadequacies of its existing 1997 version. It is also, as one source put it, a reflection of the competitive spirit between states affected by left wing extremism (LWE) when it comes to getting Maoists to surrender. A number of such states—including Odisha, Chhattisgarh, Andhra Pradesh, Telangana and Maharashtra—have tweaked their surrender policies after the Centre's 2014 Maoist Surrender and Rehabilitation Policy was unveiled, but with mixed success.

The draft policy begins by listing out the benefits and eligibility norms, and this includes both residents of MP and outsiders 'engaged in illegal activities'. It promises payment of Rs 5 lakh or the reward carried by the Maoist operative—whichever is higher—to him/ her. Besides this, an additional amount will be given for surrendered arms and ammunition. There is also a provision for amnesty for past crimes.